

The Contours of **DEI Backlash**: The Case of US Faculty

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USA
TODAY

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DEI explained: What is DEI and why is it so divisive? What you need to know.

NEWS | DIVERSITY, EQUITY AND INCLUSION

Regulatory risk | Companies flag DEI backlash as rising danger to business

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IBM Reportedly Walks Back Diversity Policies, Citing 'Inherent Tensions': Here Are All The Companies Rolling Back DEI Programs

May 19, 2026

Our Institutions Fumbled DEI; As Always, It Falls to Individuals to Do the Work

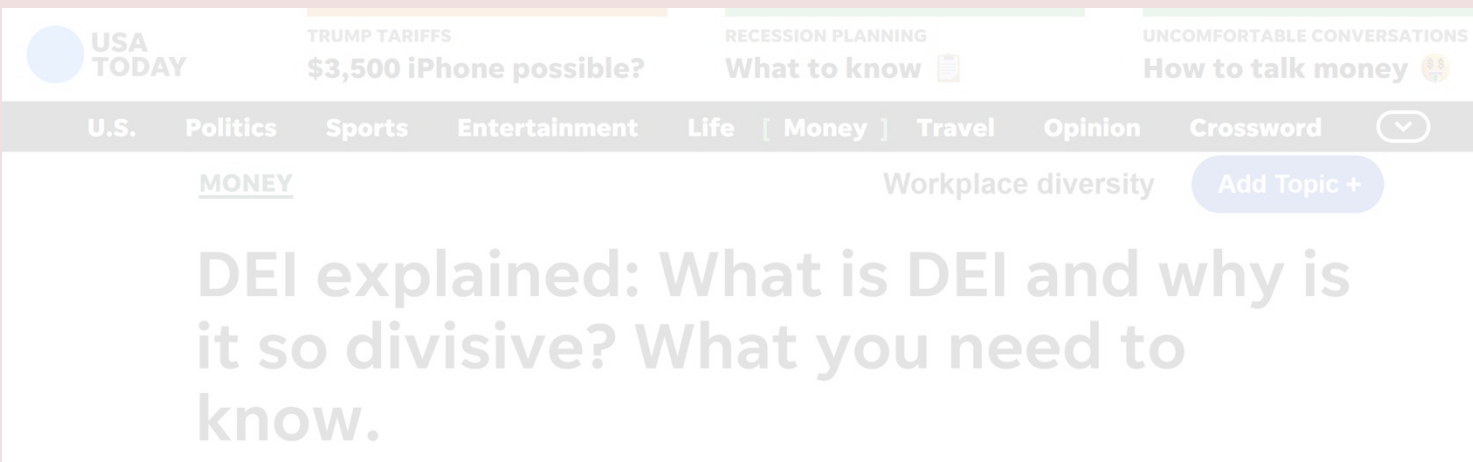
Many DEI trainings were nonscientific and ineffective. But the best of them were grounded in cognitive-behavioral strategies that we can still use in our practical, everyday work.

Apr 2, 2024 - Business

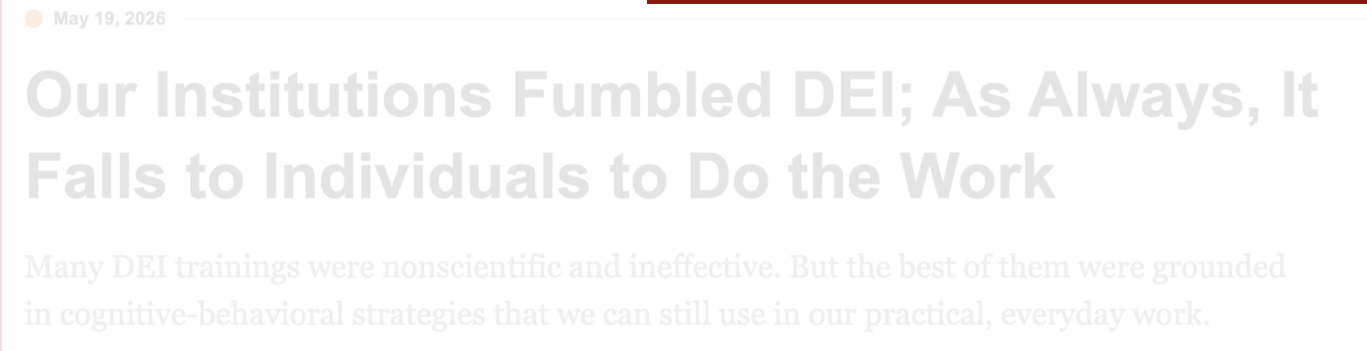
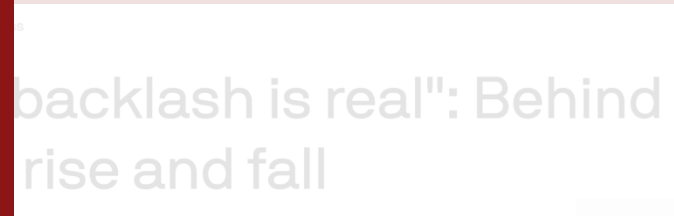
"The backlash is real": Behind DEI's rise and fall

The backlash against diversity, equity and inclusion in business is in full force – but myths obscure the real value of DEI

Published: April 11, 2024 8:27am EDT



We know DEI backlash exists and is growing, but we know surprisingly little about its *contours*: who expresses it, what form it takes, and crucially, what is actually being lashed against.



DEI Backlash

Prior research evaluates the (in)effectiveness **of specific organizational practices** intended to increase diversity

There is relatively less research on DEI backlash **as a social and organizational phenomenon**

Here, using a perhaps unexpected case of university faculty, we analyze **how workers frame opposition to diversity-related initiatives in their workplaces** and who is expressing backlash

Chang et al. 2019; Dobbin, Schrage, and Kalev 2015; Kalev, Dobbin, and Kelly 2006; Paluck and Green 2009

Study of US Tenure-Line Faculty

Survey of **10,071 current and former faculty** representing nearly all U.S. PhD granting institutions and 29 fields of study

Quantitative analysis focused on retention

Mixed methods analysis using 6,615 free text responses to an open-ended question about stress

When analyzing the qualitative data, **we noticed an interesting pattern....**

Spoon et al. 2023, 2026

A Simple Question with Polar Answers

“Tell us your story: what needs to be different in order to reduce the stress you feel in your position?”

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Many normal/expected answers: funding, workload, toxic colleagues, ...

A Simple Question with Polar Answers

“Tell us your story: what needs to be different in order to reduce the stress you feel in your position?”

Women most likely to say devaluation based on gender (and, for women of color, race) (Spoon et al. 2026)

Smaller but sizeable group (N=116) said DEI initiatives

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Surprising! Spontaneous, unprompted expressions of backlash – reduces social desirability concerns

Who expresses backlash?

What forms does it take?

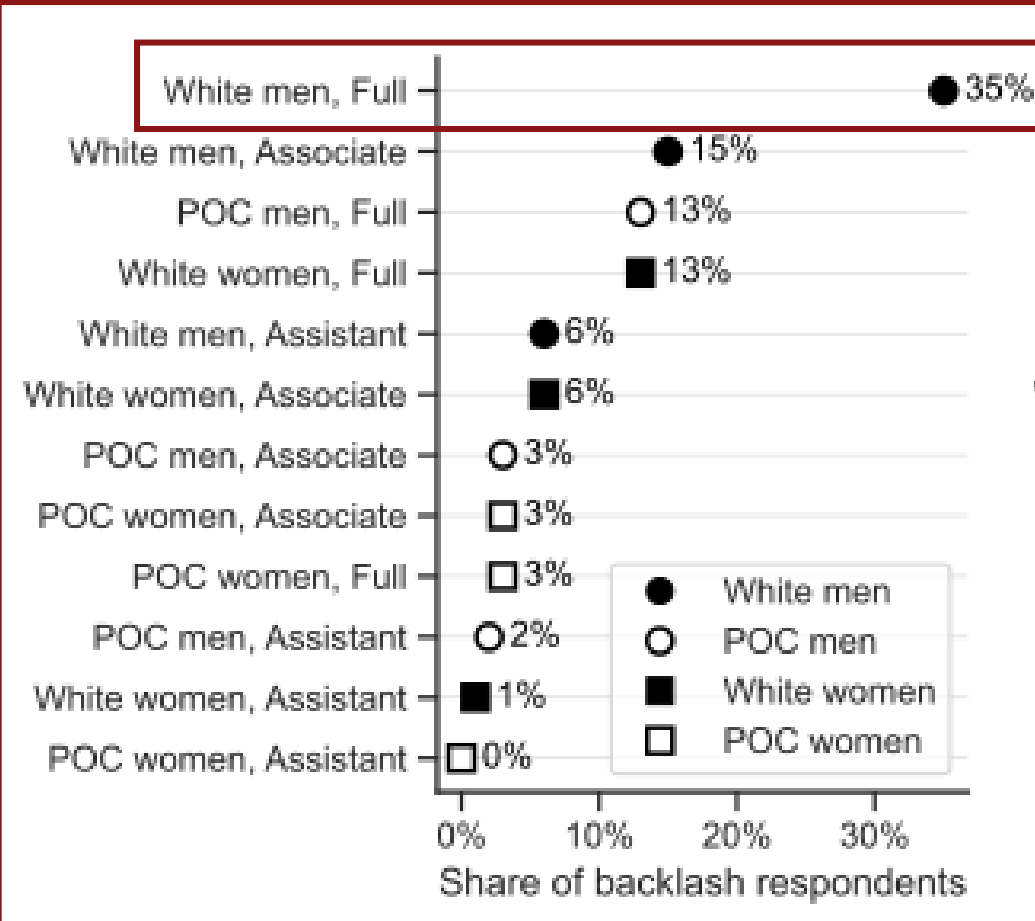
What is being lashed against?

Who expresses backlash?

What forms does it take?

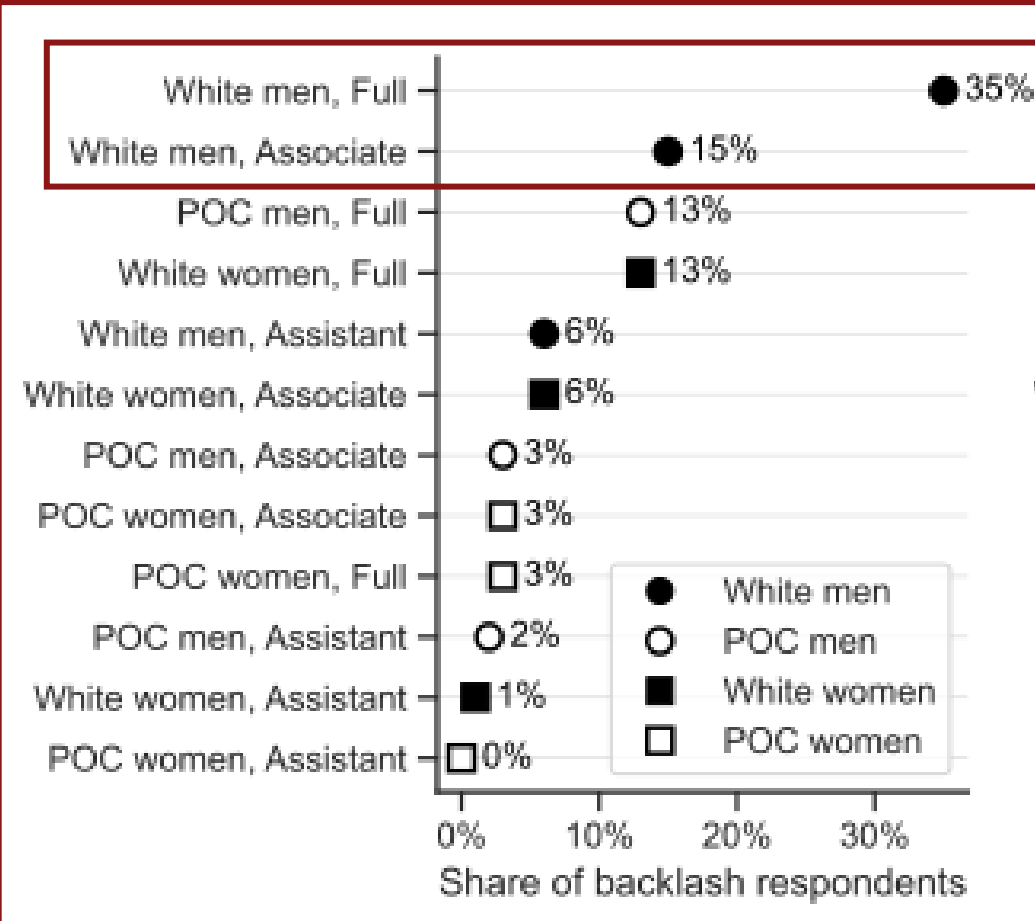
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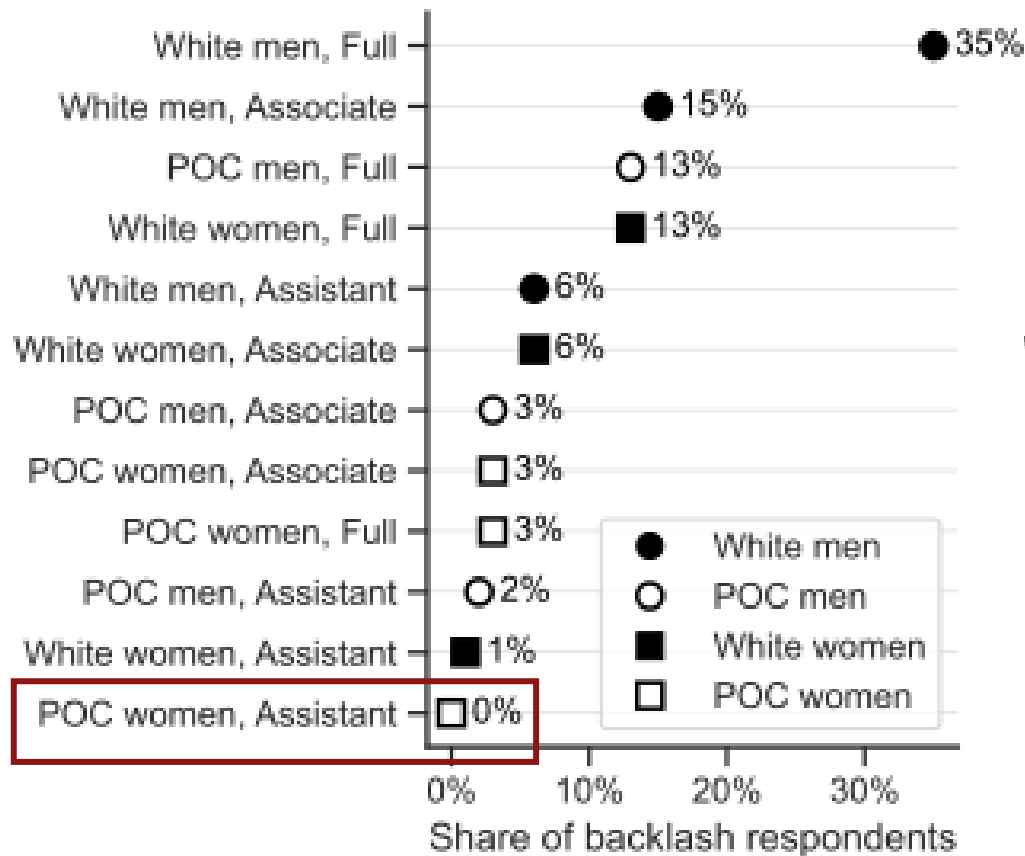
White men Full professors made up the biggest share

Who expresses backlash?



White men Full professors made up the biggest share
But tenured White men only made up half!

Who expresses backlash?



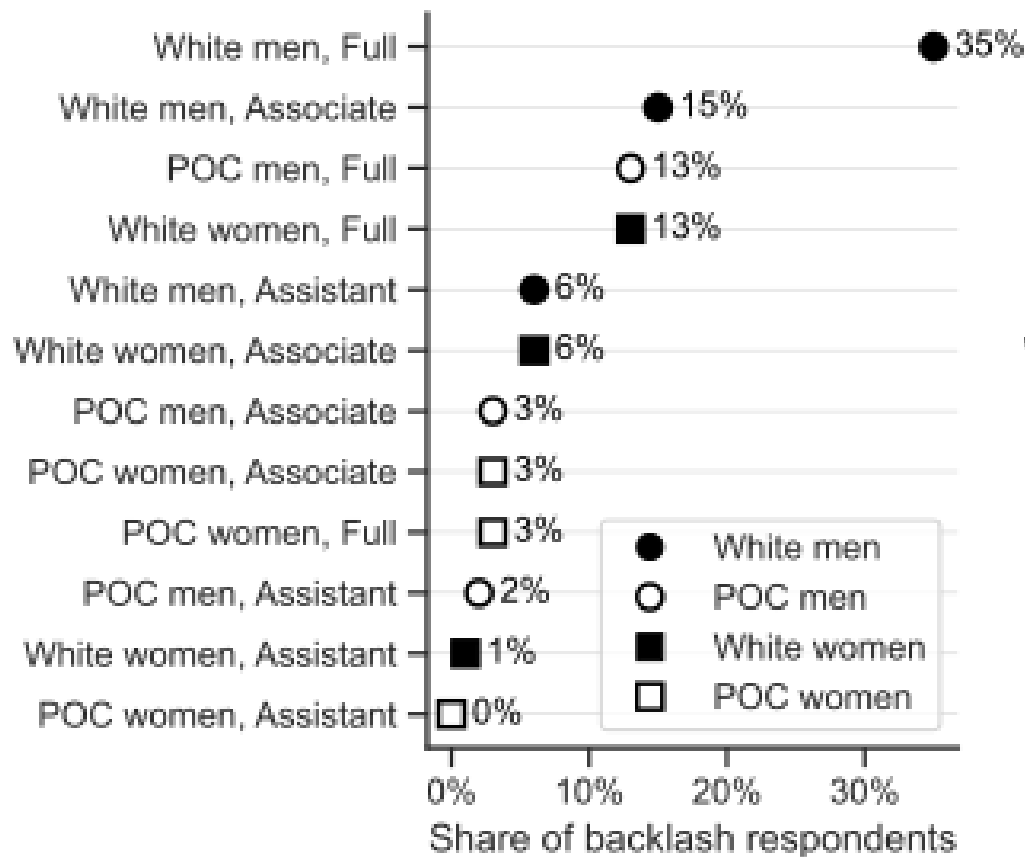
White men Full professors made up the biggest share

But tenured White men only made up half!

Women of color assistant professors make up none

POC = Asian, Hispanic (only one Black professor in our sample)

Who expresses backlash?



Many explicitly identified as liberal, a pattern that reveals greater ideological complexity than existing frameworks of conservative backlash would suggest.

Who expresses backlash?

What forms does it take?

What is being lashed against?

Existence

Effectiveness

Extent

Status erosion

Existence

Unnecessary

Incompatible with
core academic values

Actively corrupting
scholarship

Rejected the existence of DEI altogether



One White male full professor in the social sciences stated:

“One shouldn't have to be a political activist to get a teaching job in a university, or to get a promotion or a raise...It's just out of control. So if you want to know what's bothering me about my job, it's that. Everything else about it is great, and I have zero complaints.”

One Hispanic male assistant professor in the social sciences stated:

“My MAIN source of stress at work is the ideological homogenization of academia, though, in particular my discipline. I have less and less respect for my own discipline every day. You can say “because the moon is made of green cheese, we must fight white supremacy” and then you'll get published. I am not right wing but I am fed up with the woke.”

Existence

Unnecessary

Incompatible with
core academic values

Actively corrupting
scholarship

Effectiveness

Broadly
ineffective

Performative

Accepted the goals of DEI but explicitly opposed how such initiatives were implemented

One White woman full professor in STEM stated:



“Stop with the incessant DEI programs that are not helping. Instead, implement useful programs.”

One Black woman full professor in the social sciences stated:

“Hand picked women of color or white women are placed in positions of influence to perpetuate a more compliant environment. Where there would be a robust social justice focus there is now a sanitized "inclusive excellence" focus, where white women are the face of equity in public and there is no real positive social change in our program.”

Existence

Unnecessary

Incompatible with
core academic values

Actively corrupting
scholarship

Effectiveness

Broadly
ineffective

Performative

Extent

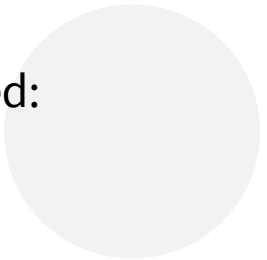
Too time consuming

Too much emphasis

Forced on faculty

Concerned with how much space, attention, and institutional priority DEI initiatives occupied.

One White male full professor in the social sciences stated:



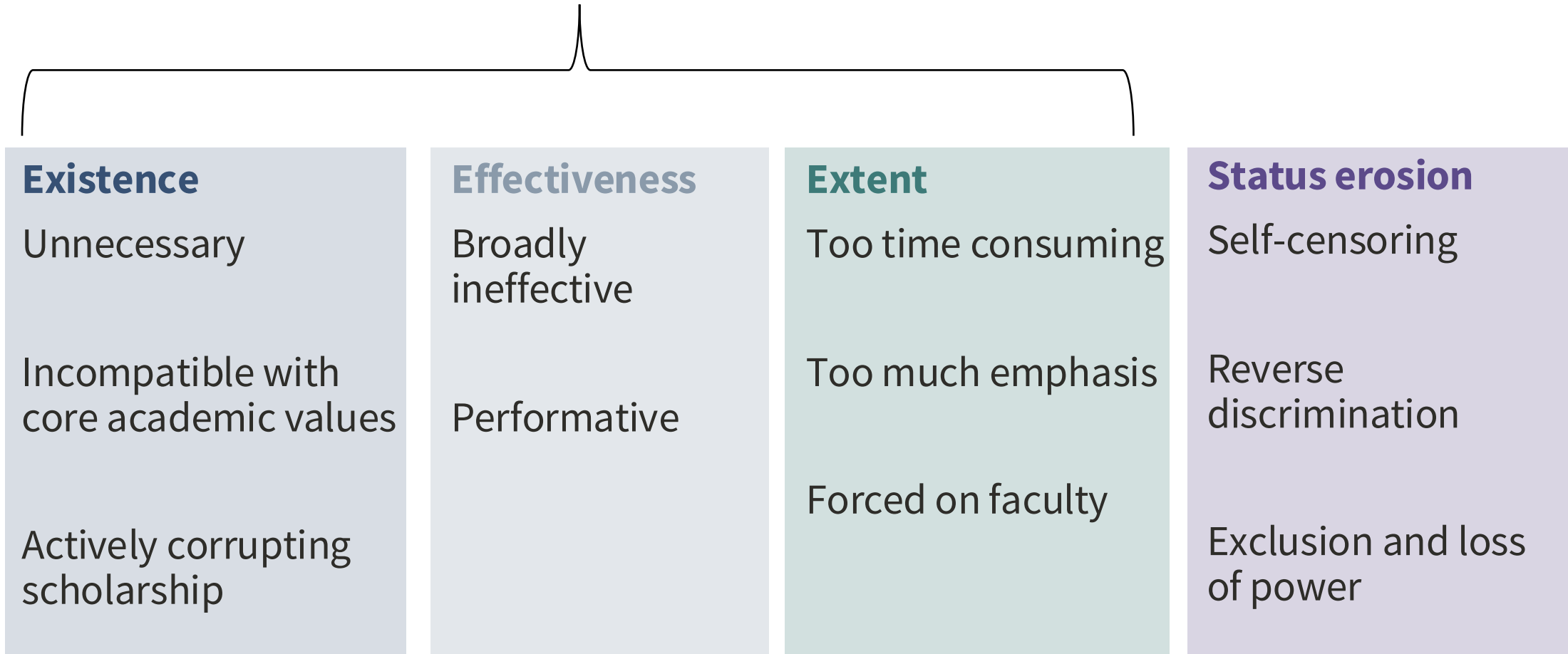
“I believe in diversity, equity, and inclusion, but I also believe that it's become an obsession that is genuinely detracting from the quality of my daily life in my university.”

One White woman associate professor in STEM stated:

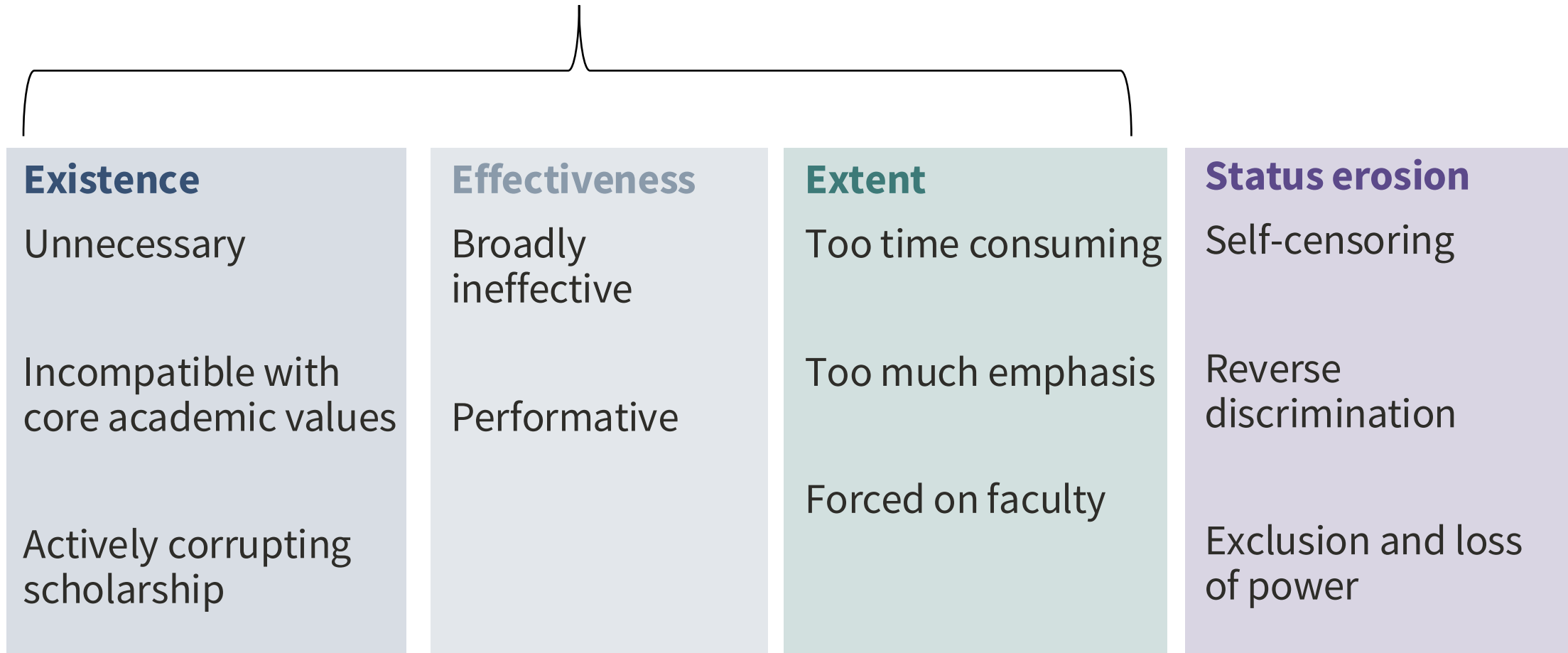


“I care deeply about racial and gender discrimination and am deeply involved in multiple outreach programs to promote diversity in STEM, but I really wish that these matters could be addressed by the administration in a less overbearing, constant background noise sort of way.”

often framed DEI as an institutional misalignment rather than a personal threat



often framed DEI as an institutional misalignment rather than a personal threat

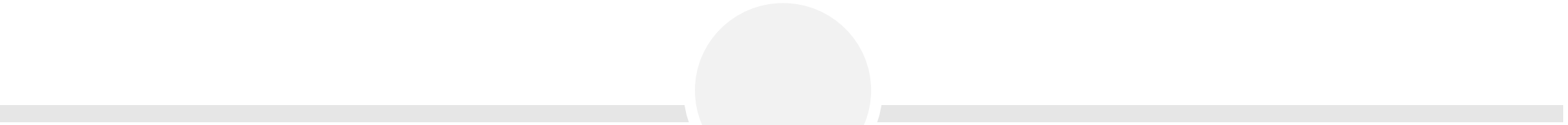


Included a more acute sense of personal loss, positioning DEI not just as a flawed initiative but as a threat to their positions in the academic hierarchy.



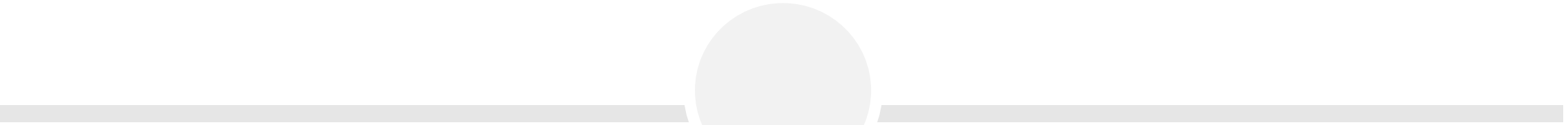
One male full professor in the social sciences stated:

“This is the source of most of my job stress these days—feeling like I have to keep my mouth shut when I disagree.”



One White male full professor in STEM stated:

“I feel that I am being overlooked for advanced administrative positions and research awards because of my race (white) and gender (male)...While I support diversity, equity, and inclusion, it has worked against me late in my career...Fortunately, I made several advances and received several awards earlier in my career.”



One White male full professor in humanities stated:

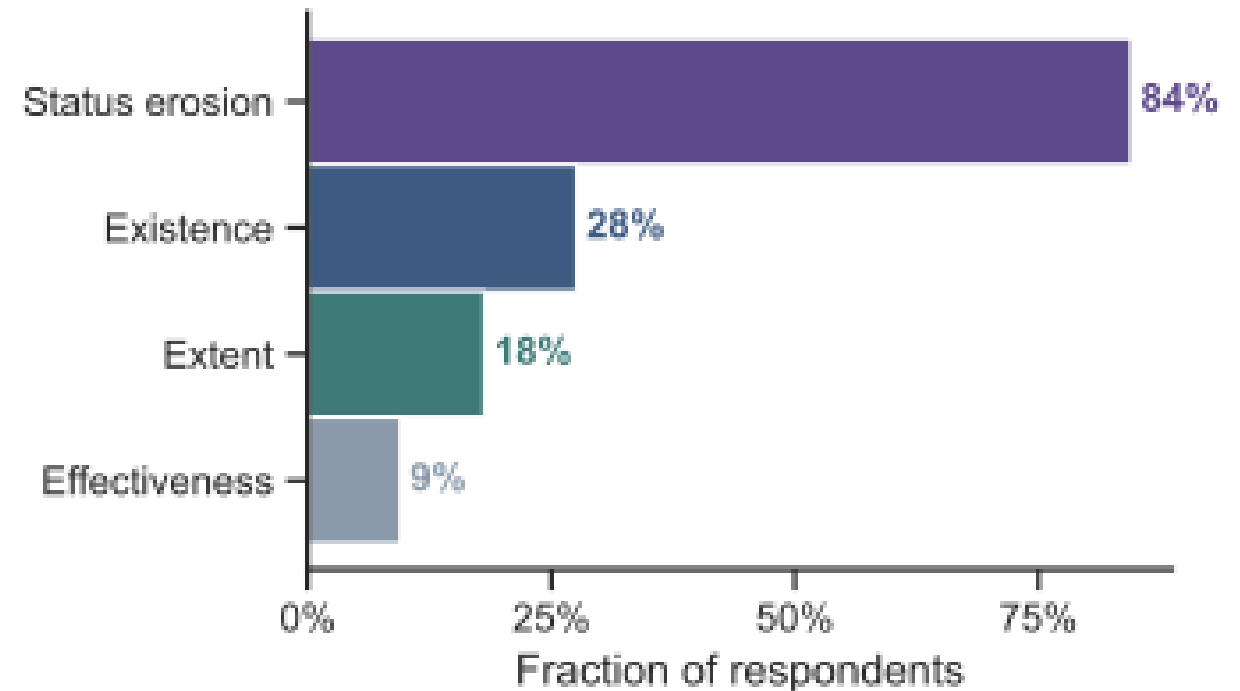
“Once I was invited to participate in an academic study of professional stress. As someone who is under constant stress at work, I was eager to participate. In the course of the survey, it became apparent that the study was geared exclusively to finding and evaluating stress factors for women and minorities. Since I don't belong to either group, it was clear that the study would disregard my results. The stress I feel will be deemed insignificant, maybe even well-deserved, and certainly unworthy of any effort to correct or mitigate.”

Who expresses backlash?

What forms does it take?

What is being lashed against?

**Not the practices themselves,
but the redistribution of status
they signal!**



Categories not mutually exclusive

Summary

Backlash was most commonly—but not exclusively—expressed by members of historically dominant groups, including White faculty and men

In our sample, the most common form of backlash was grounded in a sense of erosion of personal status; common across many demographic groups and fields

Interesting demographic differences in the sub-themes of backlash (eg, men were 5x more likely to mention reverse discrimination than women)

The source of opposition isn't primarily the programs: it's the perceived redistribution of status they signal.

Implications

While prior sociological work situates DEI backlash in the details of the practices themselves or individual attitudes, our findings suggest that DEI backlash is a fundamentally **intergroup phenomenon grounded in relative status dynamics and perceived status threat**

Interventions that either circumvent or directly target these dynamics represent promising avenues of change

(Blair-Loy and Cech 2022; Dobbin and Kalev 2022; Weisshaar et al. 2024; Edelman 2016; Danbold, Onyeador, and Unzueta 2022)

Thank you



Leslie Ekpe
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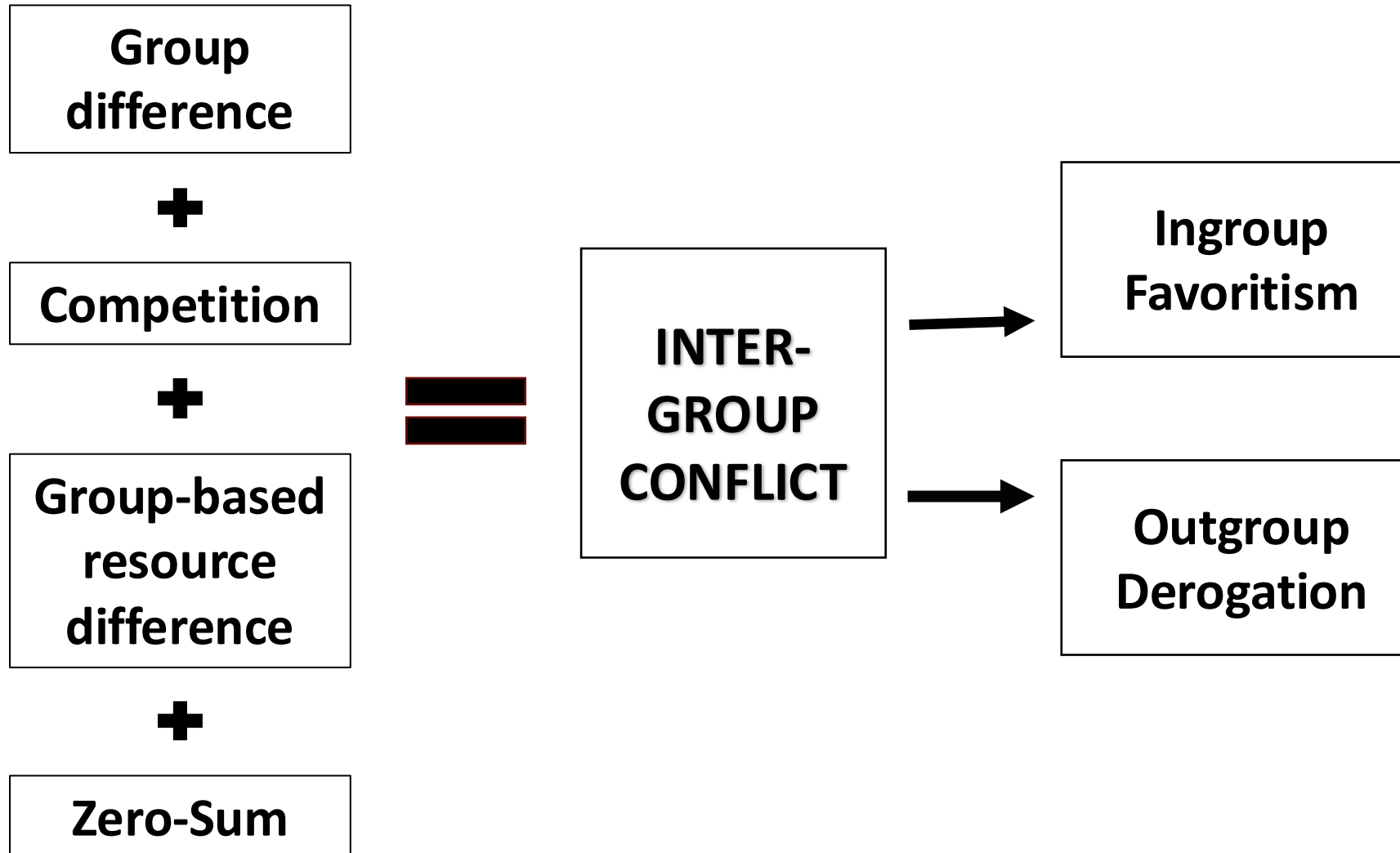
Lauren Rivera
Northwestern University

Improving lives through learning

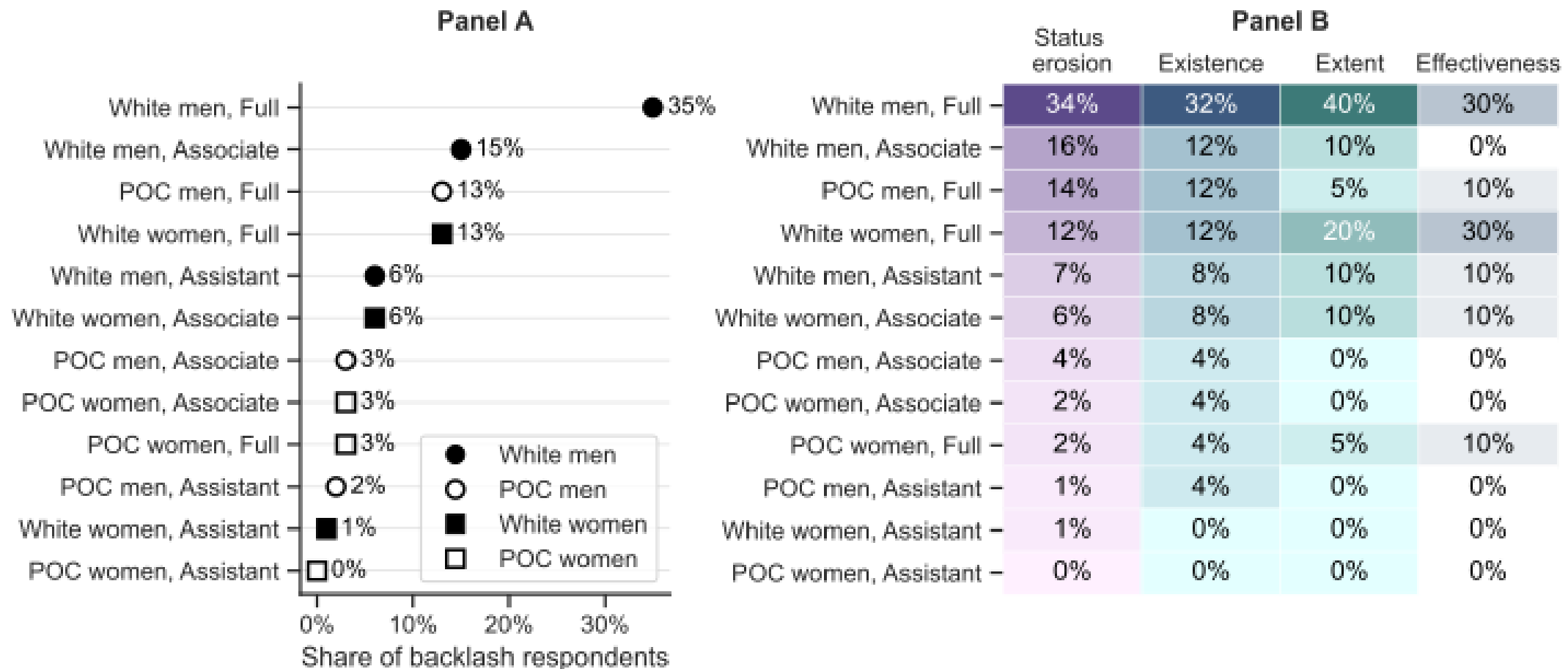
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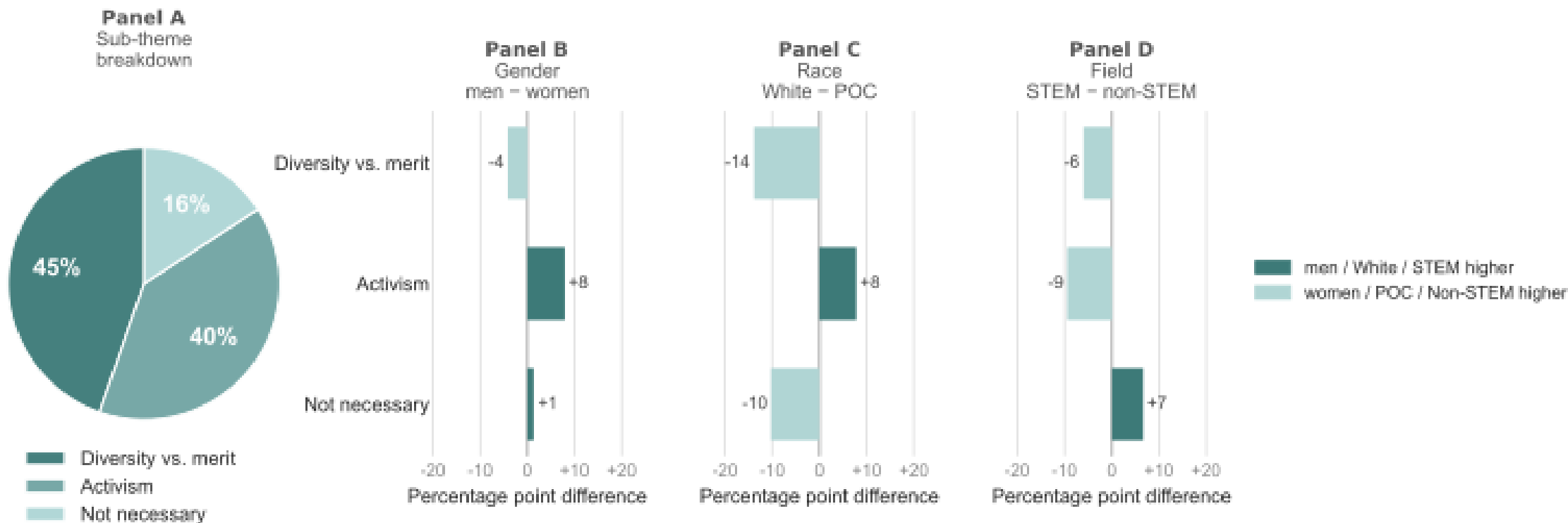
When Does Intergroup Conflict Emerge?



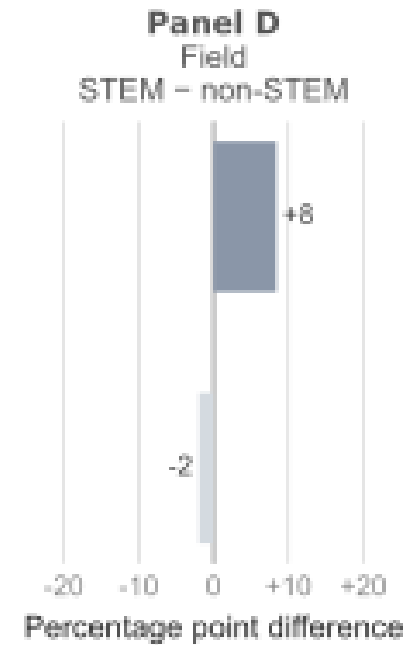
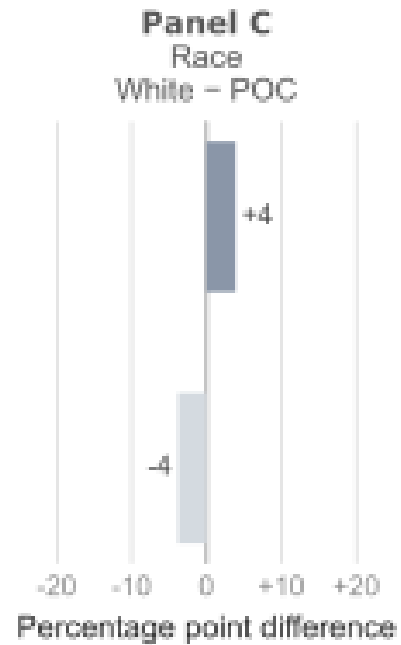
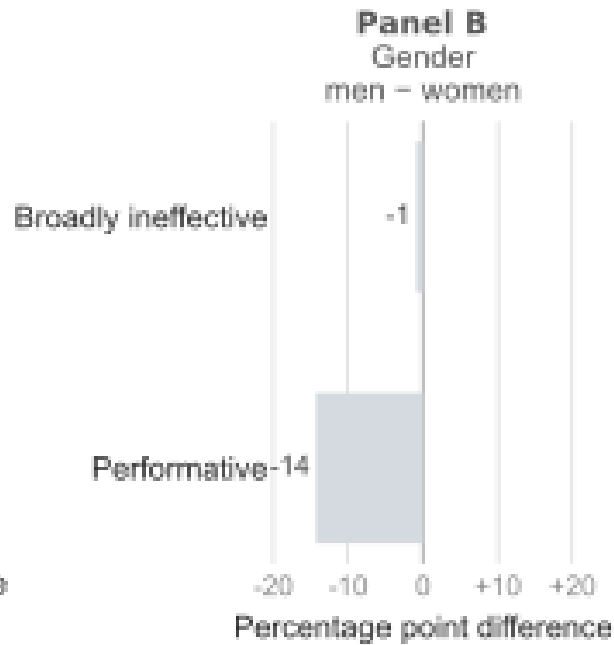
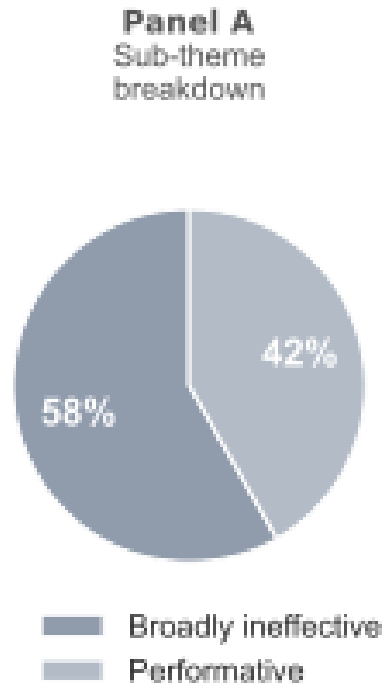
Code	Definition
EXISTENCE	
Diversity vs. merit	A focus on diversity is incompatible with merit-based systems; diversity lowers the bar; DEI hires are not qualified.
Activism	DEI is activism incompatible with science or objective scholarship; pushing agendas rather than solving real problems.
Not necessary	DEI programs are unnecessary, superfluous, or inessential; their existence is problematic.
EFFECTIVENESS	
Broadly ineffective	Broad statements that DEI programs are ineffective or haven't worked; DEI practices and policies not working.
Performative	DEI programs are ceremonial or window dressing rather than attempts to create real change.
EXTENT	
Too extreme	Mentions quantity or extremeness of DEI—too much (e.g., “it has consumed my university”).
Too much time	Mentions of DEI as taking up too much time, energy, or effort; too burdensome administratively; having additional assigned duties.
Forced	Mentions of DEI as imposed by departments, universities, chairs, etc. from the outside, or forced/mandatory.
STATUS EROSION	
Self-censoring	Not wanting to be singled out as “racist” or not “on board.” Having to be careful to avoid negative consequences; fear of cancel culture.
Exclusion and power loss	Feeling no longer centered or having the same voice or clout; a new sense of exclusion or devaluation; loss of autonomy to make decisions; exclusion of majority group thoughts in meetings/initiatives; one's identity is not being prioritized.
Reverse discrimination	Mentions that majority groups are being discriminated against (e.g., underrepresented minorities and women given explicit preference).
Not the right focus	DEI was unduly focused on race and gender rather than viewpoint, political, SES, or religious diversity.



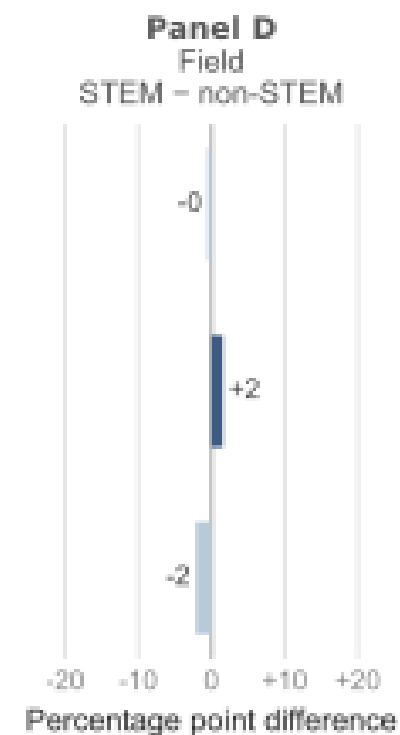
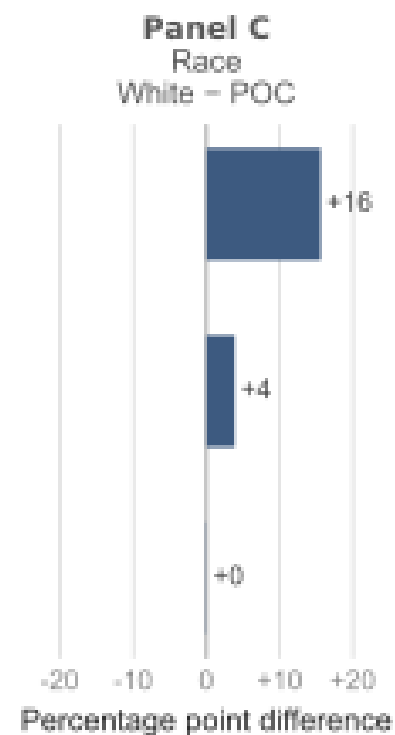
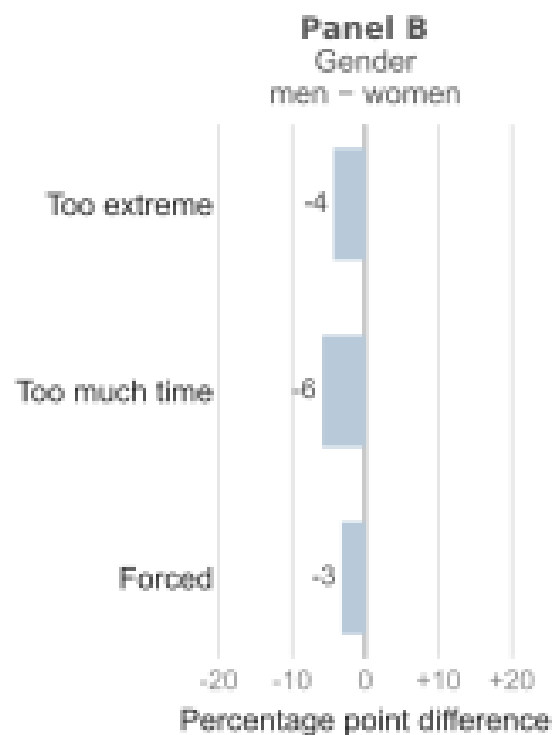
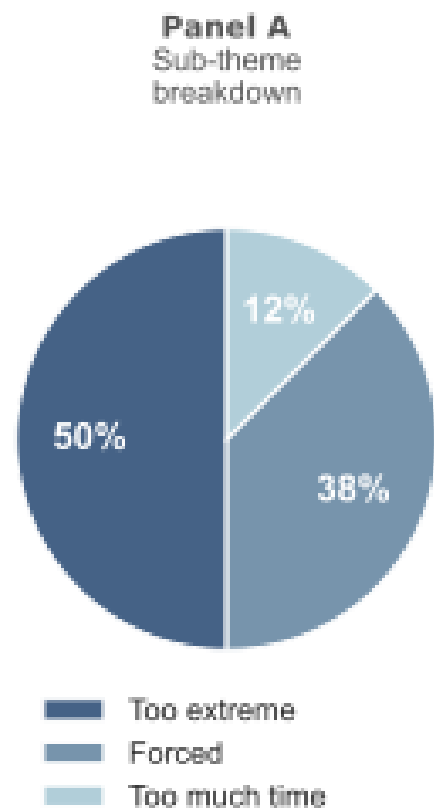
Notes: **Panel A** shows the share of total respondents articulating backlash overall from each demographic group, by gender, race, and academic rank (N=116). Circles indicate men; squares indicate women. Open markers indicate faculty of color; filled markers indicate White faculty. **Panel B** shows the demographic composition of participants articulating each type of backlash, organized by demographic groups listed in Panel A.



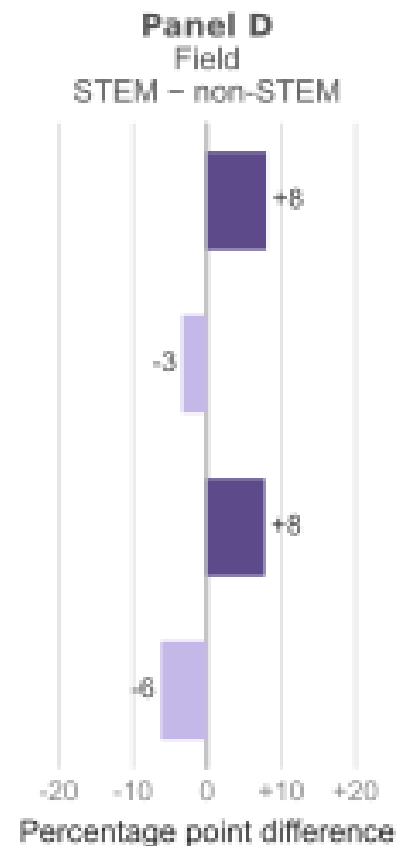
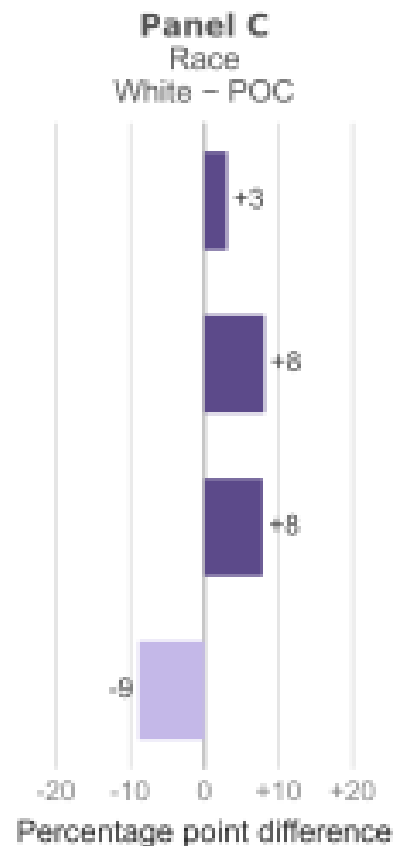
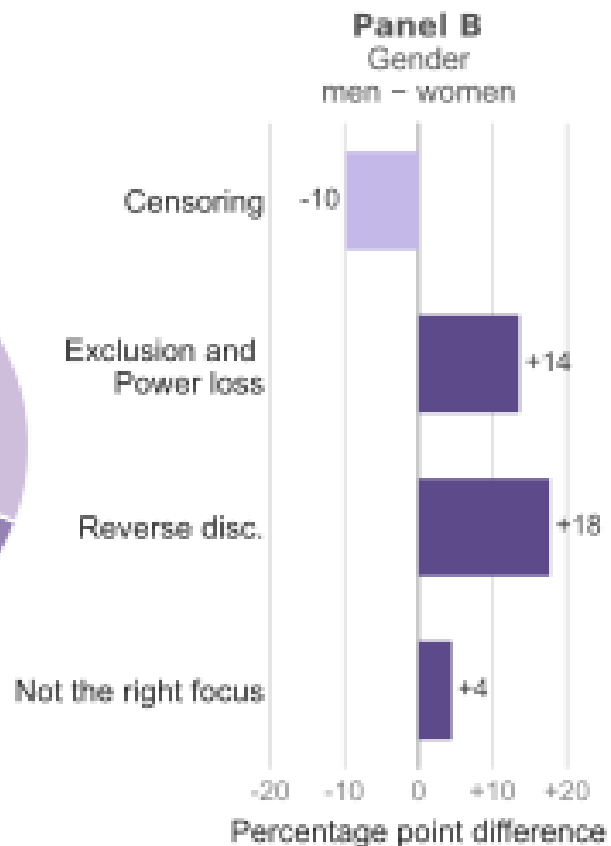
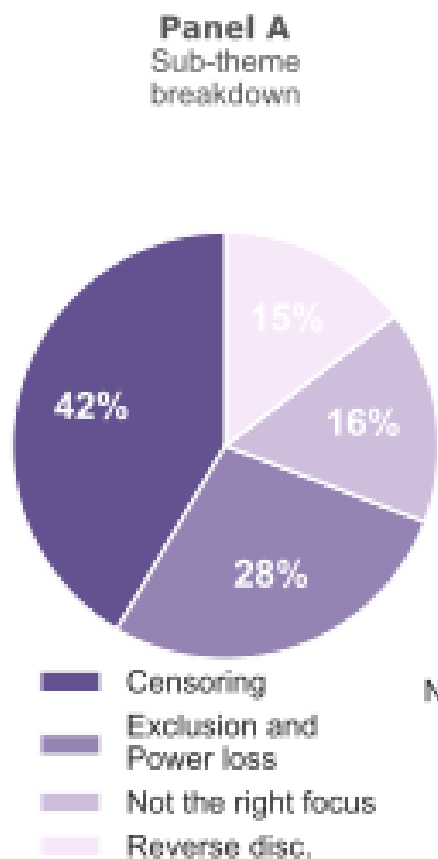
Notes: **Panel A** shows the fraction of mentions of each existence-based sub-theme. Percentage point differences between demographic groups by gender (**Panel B**), race (**Panel C**), and field (**Panel D**) in rates of expressing each existence-based sub-theme. Positive values indicate higher rates among the first-named group (men, White faculty, STEM faculty); negative values indicate higher rates among the second-named group (women, faculty of color, non-STEM faculty).



■ men / White / STEM higher
■ women / POC / Non-STEM higher



men / White / STEM higher
women / POC / Non-STEM higher



men / White / STEM higher
women / POC / Non-STEM higher